TRAIL TOOL

Career Research Guide

One career, researched well. Then an honest look at whether it fits you.

Work through the five sections in order. The first three are research: what the job is, what the numbers say, and what the work is really like. The last two are where it gets personal.

Lesson 8.2: Research Your Career shows you how to use Career Coach and O*NET for each section.

Two ways to use this handout. It matches the Career Research Guide in the Pathfinder Guidebook. Print it and fill it in by hand, or type in the boxes and save it as a PDF. Upload a photo, scan, or PDF with Mile Marker #8 in Blackboard.

NAME

DATE

RESEARCH SOURCES

Career Coach (owensboro.lightcastcc.com): regional salary, job outlook, and OCTC programs
O*NET OnLine (onetonline.org): tasks, skills, work styles, and work context
OCTC Program Finder: the Job Outlook section on each OCTC program page
Occupational Outlook Handbook (bls.gov/ooh): national pay and outlook
Job postings on Handshake, Indeed, or Glassdoor: what employers are actually asking for

SECTION 1

The basics

Be specific. "Health care" isn't a career. "Registered Nurse" is.

Job title

Industry or field

Education and training required. Which program at OCTC, or elsewhere, gets you there?

Specific skills needed: technical skills, software, certifications, or licenses

Sources I used

SECTION 2

The numbers

Use Career Coach for regional numbers and the Occupational Outlook Handbook for national ones.

Salary range in our region

National median salary

Job outlook *(choose one)*

☐ Growing ☐ Stable ☐ Declining

What's driving the outlook? (For example: technology, an aging population, policy, automation)

SECTION 3

The reality of the work

This is what most career research skips: what the work actually looks and feels like day to day.

Typical work environment. Office, outdoors, clinical, remote, school, warehouse, lab, traveling?

Typical schedule and hours (days, nights, weekends, on call, flexible?)

Dress code (scrubs, uniform, business casual, casual?)

People load *(choose one)*

☐ Mostly solo work ☐ Small team or colleagues ☐ Heavy public, patient, or client contact

☐ Varies

Pace and pressure *(choose one)*

☐ High pressure, fast-paced ☐ Steady and predictable ☐ Highly variable

Physical demands. Sitting, on your feet, lifting, driving, traveling?

SECTION 4

The fit analysis

Connect what you found to what you know about yourself from Modules 3, 6, and 7.

Strengths: where do your HIGH5 strengths show up in the demands of this career? Be specific. Don't just list your strengths.

Values: where my values are honored

Values: where there may be friction

Work environment: how does the setting fit how you work best?

Pressure: how does this career's pace and pressure compare with how much pressure you handle well?

Academic path: how does the education this career requires connect to the direction you explored in Module 6?

Life management: how do the schedule, pace, and physical demands fit how you manage your time and energy now?

Overall fit *(choose one)*

- ☐ Strong fit
- ☐ Mostly fits, with some friction
- ☐ Mixed, needs more exploration
- ☐ Probably not right for me

SECTION 5

Your honest assessment

Why this career pulls you. Mile Marker #8, Question 3 asks for the rest: one alignment, one friction, and the question you still have.

Three reasons this career interests you. Go deeper than "it pays well."

Reason 1

Reason 2

Reason 3

BEFORE YOU WRITE

Synthesis

In two or three sentences: what do you know now that you didn't before, and what does it change about how you're thinking about your direction?